

Main

Report Name (Org_Country_Year_Report Type)

IRC_Kenya_2024-25_3-month Report

Fellowship Organization

International Rescue Committee (IRC)

Fellowship City

Nairobi

Fellowship Country

Kenya

Fellowship Start Date

08/01/2024

Anticipated Fellowship End Date

07/31/2025

What is your fellowship title/role?

Grants and Accountability PiA Fellow

What are your primary responsibilities?

- Conducting comprehensive stakeholder mapping to identify key partners and opportunities and develop a business development plan aligned with the organization's strategic goals.
- Compiling proposal packages and maintaining accurate grant records and tracking tools to ensure effective documentation, implementation, reporting, and project tracking.
- Overseeing monthly reporting schedules by coordinating program team inputs, reviewing report drafts, and ensuring timely submission.

I receive adequate direction and support to perform my fellowship responsibilities.

Agree

Did you receive any sort of orientation, handover or onboarding when you started your fellowship?

Yes

Please describe your orientation/onboarding and note who handled it.

On my first day I had a meeting with the previous fellow who gave me a breakdown of the job, the following week I had meetings with two people on my team on separate occasions, one provided a insight on a grant I will be handling and the other on the systems used. Furthermore, HR schedules orientation meetings with each department which are still ongoing. I had meetings with my supervisor and the director of my department to figure out where I fit in with the transitions in the department. Finally the organization has a learning platform with courses on the workplace and systems which I took some on my free time to help me with my transition into the job.

If you did not receive any kind of orientation, what information or guidance were you provided at the start of your fellowship?**Describe a representative day at work.**

As a Grants and Accountability Fellow, my day involves reviewing emails and organizing my tasks, business development, proposal, reporting work, and meetings. This involves coordinating with colleagues and conducting stakeholder mapping to identify new partnership opportunities. This work supports our strategic goals and ensures we are well-prepared for upcoming funding opportunities. Then, I focus on grants management and reporting. This includes updating grant records, tracking project documentation, and coordinating with program teams to gather necessary inputs for our monthly reports. I carefully review and edit drafts to ensure clarity and compliance with donor requirements. Finally, I respond to any outstanding emails, update my task list, and ensure all documentation is organized and up-to-date.

On average, how many hours per week do you work?

40

How would you describe your effectiveness in your fellowship post so far?

Effective

Please briefly describe 1-2 specific projects that you have undertaken or accomplishments you have made so far.

I have worked on multiple projects, but one I am proud of because it came out of my initiative and has gained traction is the Budget versus Actual spending tracker. We have a BvA meeting for all active grants each month where spending is reviewed extensively and planning for future spending is made. In my second month, I was facilitating the meeting and realized that there was no follow-up of action points or continuation of goals. The same promises made in the previous month's meeting were made again with little accountability or follow-up. Therefore, to increase productivity, I created an action point tracker for these meetings where all action points had a lead person, a deadline, feedback, and comments section. This tracker is a live document that is followed by all involved and ensures that all focal persons have provided feedback before the next BvA meeting, ensuring accountability and continuity of goals. These are reviewed at the beginning of each meeting then the meeting proceeds by building on the action points. The initiative has gained traction and applied to other sectors of the organization, especially in project implementation.

What is your organization's work culture like?

What is your office environment like? Please comment on the size and structure of the office(s) where you do most of your work.

The Organization is on the third and fourth floors of a building that goes up to the fifth floor and has three parking basements that also have the IRC gym the organization set up for staff. The building is among four buildings in the compound that hosts other organizations. The office is very secure with open seating for most staff except for senior management. My department sits on the fourth floor where I briefly sat with them in my first two months to learn the job before I relocated to the third floor because of lack of space on the fourth floor. I do most of my work in the office except for a few occasions I was unwell or had tight deadlines and worked after hours from home.

To whom do you report?

I report to the Senior Grants Coordinator.

Have you had an initial check-in with your supervisor to set up a work plan and to set goals for your work during your fellowship year?

Yes

Was this meeting helpful in understanding your role and setting goals for your fellowship year?

The meeting was essential in figuring out where I could fit in among the transitions. I am yet to create a workplan because my permanent supervisor is yet to be hired therefore my role might change.

Please explain why you have not met with your supervisor and if you have plans to do so going forward.

Please briefly indicate 3-5 professional goals you have for the rest of your fellowship year. Your professional goals should align with your work plan.

1. Develop a business development plan for the organization
2. Become proficient in proposal development
3. Expand on my donor relationship creation and building knowledge and skills
4. Streamline grants management

How often do you check in with your supervisor?

Irregularly

Have you had an opportunity to travel for work so far?

No

Describe this travel opportunity. Include location(s) and a brief description of the purpose of the trip(s).

I feel adequately prepared for my position's professional responsibilities.

Agree

Please briefly explain your response.

While I feel confident in my position and the experience I have gained, I am mindful that it has only been a few months and each day I learn something new that gives me more confidence in my professional role. Therefore, while I am confident in my professional responsibilities, I believe the upcoming months have so much more to offer that will make me even better prepared for my professional responsibilities by the end of the fellowship.

How did you travel to your host country and site? Please be specific

I was already based in my host country pursuing further studies at a local university therefore, I had no need to travel from my home country to the fellowship site. The International Rescue Committee requested my home address and a date and time I was ready to transition to the organization's guest house. I was in contact with IRC's administrative and transport managers, who arranged for a taxi service to pick me up from my home and take me to the guest house. For my return trip, I am still in discussions with Human Resources, who will book me a flight back to my home country.

What kind of visa/ permit do you have or applied for?

I have a student Visa

How did you obtain (or are obtaining) your visa or permit?

My Visa was processed By USIU when I was a student at the school

Did you apply for and receive your visa / permit before heading to your host country or after arriving?

I renewed an existing student pass while in the host country a week before starting at my host organization.

What costs were associated with obtaining your visa or permit?

\$105 for the student pass and around \$50 for an alien card

Did you pay the visa / permit costs or were they covered by your organization?

I paid for my visa and all associated costs

Are you still having challenges obtaining your visa/ permit?

Yes

If yes, please explain further

I had challenges communicating with the host organization, hence my visa was processed by the university

g) Do you have any suggestions to help future Fellows navigate the visa / permit application process?

Initiate communication early, conduct extensive research on visa requirements and be knowledgeable enough to process your own visa in case the need arises.

What vaccinations were you required to obtain prior to your departure? How much did your vaccinations cost? Did you get a yellow fever vaccination?

I was not required to have any vaccines but I did take some vaccines which were free at public hospitals in my home country

How was your arrival and first week in your host country? Any improvements that could streamline the assimilation process for future Fellows?

My first week was slow; I arrived in the middle of a major workshop in one of the organization's field locations, which involved several key personnel for my induction process, such as my supervisor therefore, for the first few weeks I focused on completing the mandatory courses offered by the organization. I was already based in the host country I did not feel the need to assimilate outside the workplace. In-depth communication with the supervisor setting expectations before the fellow's arrival date would help streamline the assimilation process for future fellows.

Is housing provided by and/or paid for by your organization? Please explain.

Housing is provided and paid for by the host organization, all bills, maintenance, upkeep, and household supplies are handled by the organization.

Do you live in a location that is more urban or rural?

Very Urban

Please describe your living environment

We live in a secure area that is close to many amenities and surrounded by various embassies and apartment and office buildings.

How do you typically travel between your home and your work? How much does your daily transportation cost and how long is your commute?

I walk about two blocks from home to my office, this walk takes less than 5 minutes and it does not cost anything to commute to work.

If you live in a more rural area, what are the closest urban areas you can travel to for shopping, airport, larger medical centers, etc.?

N/A

How is the weather in your host country? What season are you presently in?

Kenya is a tropical country, the weather is usually warm, it does not get too hot or too cold. We are currently in summer and it rains almost every day.

What is the appropriate clothing for work and outside of work at your fellowship post and in your community in general?

My host organization has a relaxed dress code, with anything from hoodies and sneakers to formal suits and shoes. The host community does not have a typical dress code, most dress in whatever makes them comfortable and people do not seem to mind or take notice.

How have you been spending your free time?

I spend my free time relaxing at home, hosting movie nights, or exploring local restaurants and fun activities whether alone, with my co-fellows in the host community, friends outside of the fellowship circle, or alone. There are many opportunities to socialize, Nairobi is a lively city that does not lack fun or relaxing activities.

I've been able to successfully navigate my personal/social life both back at home and at my fellowship post.

Neutral

Please briefly explain your response below.

I am a person who finds peace, joy, and decompresses by being alone and my friends and family back home understand that therefore I have maintained most relationships with long check-in calls that happen probably once a month and I keep them up to date with my day by posting fun animations that represent my current activities or mood on my WhatsApp statuses. With the fellows in my host community, I have lunch with my co-fellow each day and join in on some hangouts planned by the fellows in my host community.

Would you say you live and work in a safe area?

I live and work in a safe area, I have heard of some stories of theft in the area but have never witnessed or experienced any incident.

What precautions do you take to ensure your safety?

In my first week, I took the security induction course provided by the organization and we had a security orientation early on, and we receive security updates from the organization. I ensure to follow all security measures as informed, such as continually being aware of my surroundings, staying away from demonstrations, taking cabs from trusted and easily tracked platforms such as Uber, and limit late-night travel.

What has been your experience with crime so far? (Please note that any security or safety concerns or incidents should be reported directly to PiAf staff per PiAf safety and security protocol.)

There are a lot of scammers on social media, and there are many calls from random people claiming to have accidentally sent you money or anything to scam you.

Describe the incidence of crime and the general security situation within your city/town. Could you recommend specific areas future Fellows might consider for safe housing? What about areas that should be avoided?

It would be wise to speak to the security lead of the host organization prior to traveling to the host country for recommendations on where to find safe housing that is within the fellowship budget.

Please refer back to the goals you set for yourself before orientation. Are you working towards these goals? Have you met any of them? Changed any of them? Please explain.

I am confident that I am on the right track with my goals, I do not feel the need to change any of my goals.

Do you have any frustrations with your living arrangements, your work or your life outside of work?

Lack of separation between work and personal life with the living arrangements, when colleagues from the office have access to the housing provided by the organization, it raises security concerns and makes it hard to feel at home and not as a year-long guest without a place you can truly call your safe haven

Has there been anything that you have needed but have not been able to locate or acquire?

I have always found a way to acquire what I need, with a big community from my home country in the host community there is no shortage of individuals traveling in from my home country willing to bring me some things I might need.

How have you dealt with "culture shock"?

No

What about your experience thus far has been the most...surprising?

Office politics

What about your experience thus far has been the most...challenging?

Acclimating to the living situation. A personal goal was to learn to have a healthy work-life balance, focusing especially on setting a healthy boundary because I tend to be a workaholic, coming home to colleagues when trying to take a break and letting loose from pressing deadlines is a challenge, home feels like an extension of the office.

What are the top 3 things you miss the most from your home country or the U.S.?

- a. Lays
- b. Local foods, especially fruits such as Mangoes
- c. Safe long walks at night

What are the top 3 things about life in your host country that beat out life in your home country or the U.S.?

- a. Transport convenience
- b. Less dust
- c. The weather

How is your stipend being paid?

My stipend is paid monthly in dollars into my US account.

How are you receiving your stipend funds?

Wire

Did you raise funds to cover part of your fellowship expenses?

My family supports me with additional funds to support my fellowship expenses.

Please list any additional one-time or infrequent expenses not included in your monthly budget below.

Monthly Budget

Rent \$0.00	Utilities \$0.00	Furnishings \$100.00	Phone \$10.00	Home Security \$20.00	Internet \$20.00
Transportation \$50.00	Fitness \$0.00	Entertainment \$50.00	Groceries \$150.00	House Cleaning \$0.00	Eating Out \$100.00
Medications \$10.00	Additional Health Insurance \$0.00	Travel \$50.00	Laundry \$20.00	Other \$600.00	Total Monthly Budget (Minus Entertainment & Travel) 1080.00
Specify "Other" Gadgets, clothing, savings for retreat, etc					

Final Thoughts

Please briefly explain your response about Orientation.

It helped paint a picture and connected us to some alumni who have gone through the same experience and provided great insight

Is there anything in particular that PiAf could cover at orientation that would have better prepared you for your fellowship post? Please specify.

Tips on dealing with imposter syndrome.

Are you receiving sufficient support, materials and information from the Princeton in Africa office? What could we improve?

I am receiving sufficient support from the Princeton in Africa Office.

As we plan the upcoming PiAf Retreat, we hope to incorporate some Fellow suggestions into our programming. What are some topics or sessions you would like to see at the Retreat? (We appreciate your feedback however, we may not be able to accommodate all suggestions or requests this year.)

More sessions on navigating office politics.